



THE T-14 **TRANSFER PLAYBOOK**

When to Apply, How to Position Yourself,
and How to Stand Out Against the Competition

IvyAmbition

T14 Law School Admissions Consulting



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The Transfer Landscape

Law school transfers are one of the least understood paths in legal education. Every year, hundreds of students move from lower-ranked schools into the T-14. The process is opaque, poorly documented, and full of strategic landmines. Transfer admissions operates under **completely different rules** than first-year admissions. Your LSAT is essentially irrelevant. Your undergraduate GPA barely matters. What matters above almost everything else: **your 1L grades**.

Schools accept transfers for two reasons. Revenue: transfers typically pay full tuition since scholarships are minimal. Attrition replacement: every year students leave, and schools fill those seats. T-14 schools accept 10 to 80+ transfers per year depending on the school.

The table below shows approximate transfers **enrolled** per year based on ABA 509 disclosure data. Schools do not publish how many transfer applications they receive, so acceptance rates cannot be calculated.

School	Approx. Transfers Enrolled/Year
Georgetown	~80-120
Columbia	~50-70
NYU	~40-60
Northwestern	~25-40
Harvard	~25-40
Penn	~20-35
Michigan	~15-25

→ **KEY INSIGHT:** Georgetown, Columbia, and NYU enroll the most transfers by volume. But volume alone doesn't tell you your odds — schools don't disclose application counts. Use enrollment numbers to gauge which schools are **actively building transfer classes** vs. filling a handful of seats.

CHAPTER 02

The Transfer Timeline

Aug–Dec

Focus entirely on grades. Do not tell classmates. Build professor relationships for future recs.

January

Fall grades released. Top 10-15% = T-14 realistic. Top 5% = competitive everywhere including HYS.

Feb–March

Research targets. Draft personal statement. Approach 2 professors for recs. Keep excelling in spring.

April–May

Apps open. Submit as early as possible — many use rolling review. Finalize PS. Ensure recs submitted.

May–July

Decisions arrive rolling. Some schools decide as late as August. Negotiate if multiple offers.

August

Deadline to decide. Coordinate credit transfers, housing, financial aid.

CHAPTER 03

What Transfer Committees Evaluate

1L Grades (Dominant)

Overwhelmingly the most important factor. Top 10% at a well-regarded school = competitive at most T-14. Top 5% = competitive everywhere. Below top 15-20%, even the best materials won't overcome the numbers.

Current School Reputation

Top 5% at a T-30 ≈ top 10-15% at a T-50. Committees assess grades relative to competition quality.

Personal Statement

Must answer: **why do you need to transfer?** Not "why is this school better" but what specific need your current school cannot meet.

Letters of Recommendation

Must come from law professors. Best rec: "this student belongs at a higher-ranked institution."

Resume and Activities

Least important but differentiates similar candidates. Law review, moot court, research positions all help.

CHAPTER 04

Building Your Candidacy During 1L

1 Grades Above All Else

Your GPA is the application. Every assignment, every outline session is an investment. Everything else is secondary to exam performance.

2 Build Professor Relationships Early

You need 2 strong faculty recs. Start office hours in September, not March. Best recs come from professors who watched you engage over an entire semester.

3 Join Law Review If Possible

Strongest extracurricular signal for transfers. Demonstrates writing ability, attention to detail, academic seriousness.

4 Keep Plans Private

Don't tell classmates. Creates social friction and pressure if it doesn't work out.

5

Document Everything

Keep a running list of achievements, honors, notable contributions. You'll need this for your PS.

CHAPTER 05

The Transfer Application Package

✓ STRONG PS APPROACH

"During 1L, I discovered a deep interest in securities regulation. My current school offers one elective. Columbia offers 12 courses in corporate and securities law, the Program on Corporate Governance, and proximity to Wall Street practitioners. My SEC enforcement goals require depth only Columbia can provide."

✗ WEAK PS APPROACH

"I am applying because Columbia is more prestigious with better career opportunities. I deserve a higher-ranked institution based on my strong performance."

→ **THE RULE:** Never say "your school is better." Frame it as: "my specific academic interests require resources only your school provides."

CHAPTER 06

School Selection Strategy

1

Know Your Ceiling

Top 5% = all T-14. Top 10% = most T-14 outside HYS. Top 15% = schools ranked 8-14. Top 20% = Georgetown, Northwestern only. Below 20% = unlikely for T-14.

2**Apply to 5-8 Schools**

Transfer outcomes are volatile. Include reaches, targets, and confident picks. The \$50-\$85/app cost is trivial vs career impact.

3**Calculate the Financial Reality**

Most transfers pay full tuition for 2L and 3L — \$80K-\$150K more than staying. For BigLaw students, the salary premium typically recovers this in 3-5 years.

CHAPTER 07**After You're Accepted****1****Negotiate Financial Aid**

Transfer scholarships are scarce but not nonexistent. Use competing acceptances as leverage.

2**Confirm Credit Transfer**

Policies vary. Some schools require retaking certain courses. Confirm before committing.

3**Social Integration**

The hardest part. Join organizations immediately, attend every event in your first month, connect with other transfers.

4**Law Review Write-On**

Most T-14s allow transfer write-on participation. Critical for clerkship-bound students.

5

OCI Recruiting

Your T-14 brand opens doors. Have a concise, positive answer ready for "why did you transfer?"

WANT EXPERT TRANSFER GUIDANCE?

IvyAmbition offers Transfer Strategy Sessions with consultants who have firsthand T-14 transfer experience.

Book a free 15-minute consultation at ivyambition.com